Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Billy Collins's "Dharma"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of characterization of **both** himself and the dog in Collins's "Dharma" include

allusion,
characterization,
free verse,
imagery,
metaphor,
point of view,
rhetorical question,
theme, and
tone.

The contestant might approach his or her discussion of the speaker's characterization of both himself and his dog by addressing each separately or because we learn about the speaker's own character through his characterization of "the dog" (line 1) through the speaker's combing the two in a progression. The latter approach reveals an understanding that the poem might well be principally about the speaker.

The dog's character is developed through the speaker's appreciation of her gifts (as he recognizes them) and a criticism of her faults (as he estimates them). The dog's gifts and faults might well be seen in terms of the cat: were the dog—perhaps the speaker himself—more like the cat, which, by way of inferential comparison, is a model of self-containment (line 22) and is not dependent on a god (line 28), thus earning the speaker's "admiration" (line 7).

The speaker's description by way of allusion (lines 8-12) suggests an appreciation of the dog's level of remove from the material aspects of the world—anthropomorphism is at work here, perhaps unconscious projection: the dog, by its nature, has no need of a hat, an umbrella, keys, and money (see poem's title), but maybe this is that to which the speaker himself aspires. The student might recognize in the speaker's comment regarding his wishing that the dog was not subservient to him as if the speaker were a god—a nod toward Buddhism, which recognizes no supreme entity.

Something might be made of the gender choice for either or both the dog and the cat, especially in terms of the speaker's possibly identifying with the cat. Something of the speaker's generalization about women might be inferred throughout the lines of the final stanza.

The anti-materialism described in the opening stanza is matched by the speaker's appreciation for self-containment (self-sufficiency) and a getting along in the world without depending on or taking from others, whether human or deity (final stanza). The dog is, after all, ***the*** dog not ***his*** dog.